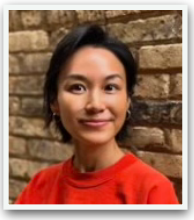
Yvonne Y. Tam

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RESEARCH & TEACHING INTERESTS

AOS: Ethics, History of Moral Theory, Kant

AOC: Social & Political Philosophy, Feminist Philosophy, Philosophy of Disability, Early Modern, Logic

ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

Northwestern University — Sept. 2025—Present
Brady Program for Ethics & Civic Life
Postdoctoral Faculty Fellow

University of California Riverside — Sept. 2022—Jun. 2025
Visiting Lecturer

University of California Riverside — Aug. 2012—Dec. 2018
Teaching Assistant, Associate Instructor

EDUCATION

PhD in Philosophy, University of California Riverside — 2025
Dissertation: *A Kantian Duty of Moral Self-Love*
Committee: Andrews Reath (chair), Agnieszka Jaworska, Andreja Novakovic, Michael Nelson

MA in Philosophy, University of Wisconsin Milwaukee — 2011
Thesis: *Justice for the Cognitively Disabled: Obligations to the Margins of Our Moral Community.*

BA in Philosophy and Gender Studies, Colgate University — 2007

DISSERTATION

A KANTIAN DUTY OF MORAL SELF-LOVE

Moral practice often invokes self-love, yet it remains largely neglected in the philosophical literature on moral self-regard. The moral tradition tends to treat self-love as an inevitable feature of human psychology that we must curb for the sake of others. Indeed, Kant infamously regards self-love as morality's chief antagonist. However, I propose that a moral conception of proper self-love can be grown on Kantian soil. This dissertation articulates a Kantian moral theoretical basis for proper self-love and argues that as members of the moral community, we have a duty of self-love because this kind of self-regard is central to our moral relations, and thus moral agency. As an alternative to Kant's more famous notion of self-interested self-love, moral self-love positively values oneself as an end-in-itself. As practical, moral self-love is a social form of self-regard that transforms how we relate to the value of our ends and enables the kind of joint willing that constitutes our participation in sustaining the integrity of our moral relations.

PRESENTATIONS& CONFERENCES

* = PEER-REVIEWED, † = INVITED

"Respecting Vulnerability: Active Sympathy & Inner Freedom in Kant's Doctrine of Virtue"
* APA Pacific Symposium, Mar. 2027 (scheduled)
† Alumni Conference in Philosophy at UC Riverside, Mar. 2026

"Rethinking Sympathy, Agency, and the Practice of Moral Community"
* Group Agency & Metaethics Workshop, International Social Ontology Society at the University of Vienna, Sept. 2026

Self-Love & Solidarity (Monograph Proposal)
Nominated for Kaplan Institute for the Humanities Dissertation-to-Book Workshop at Northwestern University, Mar. 2025

"Beyond Self-Respect: Towards a Kantian Duty of Moral Self-Love."
* Mark Sanders Mentoring Workshop for Early Career Women Faculty in Philosophy, Jun. 2025
* Love and Care Workshop at Harvard University, Sept. 2024
* Leipzig University Doctoral Conference, Jun. 2024

Comments for Bas Tönissen, "Kant's Concept of the Heart and Its Development."
† Pacific APA, Mar. 2025

"The Structure of Authority in Meta-Ethical Justification."
* Braga National Meeting for the Portuguese Society of Analytic Philosophy at the University of Minho Sept. 2012
* Salzburg Conference for Analytic Philosophy Aug. 2012

ARTICLES & MANUSCRIPTS

In Preparation (manuscripts available on request)

"Beyond Self-Respect: Towards a Kantian Duty of Moral Self-Love"

"Moral Friendship & Two Kinds of Self-love"

"Respecting Vulnerability: Sympathy and Inner Freedom in Kant's Doctrine of Virtue"

"Sympathy, Agency, and the Practice of Moral Community"

Public Philosophy

"The Moral Life": Thinking for Oneself by Thinking Together. APA Syllabus Showcase Blog, Oct. 21, 2026.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Northwestern University, Postdoctoral Faculty Fellow

Ethics & Authenticity First-Year Writing Seminar, class-size ~ 15 (Winter 2026)

The Moral Life, class-size ~ 15 (Spring 2026)

The Good Life, class-size ~ 15 (scheduled Winter 2027)

The Good Society, class-size ~ 15 (scheduled Spring 2027)

University of California Riverside, Primary Lecturer/Instructor

Philosophy of Justice, class-size ~ 30 (7 quarters)

Ethical Theory, class-size ~ 30 (Spring 2025)

Philosophy of Feminism, class-size ~ 30 (Spring 2024)

Ethics and the Meaning of Life, class-size ~ 400 (Fall 2022)

Introduction to Philosophy, class-size ~ 30 (Summers 2012, 2013)

OTHER TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of California Riverside, Teaching Assistant

Critical Thinking (5 quarters)

Ethics and the Meaning of Life (2 quarters, 1 quarter under Writing Across the Disciplines Program)

Introduction to Logic (3 quarters)

Philosophy of Evil (2 quarters)

Introduction to Law and Society

Philosophy of Law (2 quarters)

Contemporary Moral Issues

Biomedical Ethics

Early Modern Philosophy

Composition 1A (University Writing Department)

Private Tutor - Logic (Fall 2022)

SERVICE & PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

2026-27 Cohort, Reflective & Effective Teaching Program in the Searle Center for Advancing Learning and Teaching at Northwestern University

Northwestern Society for the Theory of Ethics and Politics (NUSTEP), co-organizer 2026, 2027

Referee: *Croatian Journal of Philosophy, Medusa: An Undergraduate Journal of Philosophy*

PhiloSOPHIA: A Transcontinental Society for Feminism conference, program committee member, Texas A & M University, April 2025

American Philosophical Association member

North American Kant Society member

UCR Minorities and Philosophy

"Fichtean Kantianism in 19th Century Ethics" by Michelle Koch, chair, APA Eastern Dec. 2015

Research Assistant to Agnieszka Jaworska,"The Grounds of Moral Status" Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, AY 2012/2013

REFERENCES

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Brady Scholars Program
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Associate Professor of English
Northwestern University
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DISSERTATION SUMMARY: *A KANTIAN DUTY OF MORAL SELF-LOVE*

Despite Kant's purported hostility to self-love, I articulate a Kantian moral theoretical basis for a moral kind of self-love, and argue that as members of the moral community, we have a duty of moral self-love because this kind of self-regard is central to our moral relations, and thus moral agency. I draw on Kant's foundational concept of the value of humanity, which properly understood, identifies its positive requirements towards others with *practical love*: to share in the ends of subjects who are ends-in-themselves. An alternative to Kant's famous notion of self-interested self-love, *moral* self-love positively values oneself as an end-in-itself. As practical, moral self-love is a form of self-regard that transforms how we relate to the value of our ends. This kind of moral self-love enables the sharing and giving of oneself entailed by our engagement in moral bonds.

Chapter 1-2 distinguish the kind of moral self-love at issue from prudential self-interest, and related modes of moral self-regard such as *virtuous self-esteem* and *self-respect*. I consider cases of failures of self-love that seem morally salient, and contend that prevailing accounts of moral self-regard are inadequate to justify them as failures of *moral* concern.While Aristotelian virtue ethics counts self-love as merited by virtuous moral achievement, the deontic moral tradition offers robust duties of self-respect. Neither fully explains the moral significance attached to the phenomenon of self-love, why others may have a moral interest in our self-love, or the problem of deficient self-love in contemporary moral practice. Subsequent chapters develop a unified theory of a moral duty to self-love that explains how proper self-love shares the same moral grounds as other-regarding love, the moral significance of failures of self-love and its attending duty, and self-love's role in sustaining our moral relations, and thus moral agency.

Chapter 3 argues that Kantian friendship presupposes a capacity for moral self-love. Representing ideal moral relations, friendship is characterized by practical love—in reciprocity and joint willing, and distinguished from non-moral friendship in that it is a valuing stance towards each other's ends that is grounded in the recognition of one another's dignity as persons. What distinguishes a love relation as moral is the *grounds* for adopting ends for a person's sake. This understanding of the moral relation of value in which persons stand to their ends constitutes a crucial area of practical proficiency with the moral concept of persons. Moral love thus endows the standpoint of friendship with a cognitively complex and morally sophisticated volitional structure that is disinterested yet personal. I share in my friend's ends because her ends matter because she matters. If joint willing underwrites sharing ends, friendship requires the ability to set my ends on grounds that my friend can share in for my sake, which is to say, in recognition of my dignity.

Chapter 4 argues that failures of self-love demonstrate a deficient grasp of the moral concept of persons as it pertains to oneself. Unlike failures of self-respect, they aren't just cases of undermining one's equal moral standing by waiving one's claim to moral rights. They display a relation to the value of one's ends that regards one's worth as conditional on one's success. Distorting the relation of value in which persons stand to their ends thus contradicts grounds for adopting ends out of recognition for the dignity of persons. Failures of moral self-love deny one's humanity the proper role in guiding valuing agency. Since proficiency with the moral concept of persons requires appreciating its' *practical* role, such failures exhibit a defective moral self-conception. Failures of self-love exhibit deficient moral understanding and undermines our ability to sustain a moral self-relation. So, moral self-love is a duty, not a virtuous yet optional achievement.

Chapter 5 gives moral self-love a role in countering risks to the basis of our self-worth. Given that vulnerability to the success of our ends is constitutive of valuing for agents with a sensible nature, setting ends invites assessing our own and one another's worth in terms of success or failure in those ends. How we relate to one another and the description under which we value the quality of our relationships are structured by an implicit conception of our worthiness. So, sharing ends in moral relations requires managing the vulnerability of emotionally investing in what we care about. Since valuing necessitates some positive description of value, resisting comparative or dehumanizing ascription of personal worth requires supplanting it with a morally authoritative one. This is just one's dignity as a person, who engenders value through setting ends on grounds that can be shared from the standpoint of a subject who has moral love for me, whether that is another or myself. I conclude with implications for rethinking the tension between love and duty, moral agency in the capacity to participate in moral relations, and metanormative consequences of vindicating a central role for love and sensibility in moral theory.